Yet I couldn't see that was happening. Night after night I went to bed in a mental argument with McCarthy, reliving the events of the day, trying to find the comments that the various investigating senators should have made, and I was certain that never in my life would I ever dislike any American in public life as intensely as I disliked McCarthy. (I was wrong there.)

v-

I had never gone farther than Philadelphia to attend a science-fiction convention, but Marty Greenberg persuaded me to attend the 1954 Midwescon ("Midwest Convention"), which was to be held in Bellefontaine, Ohio. He would drive.

On May 19, I drove Gertrude and David to New York, and the next morning I went to the Golds'. Marty intended to come there and pick up Evelyn Gold. Also in the car was Marty's accountant, a very nice fellow who must have had difficulty remaining sane if he seriously tried to handle Marty's books.

Though Marty might be a reluctant disburser of money, he was an excellent driver, and he got us to Bellefontaine on the twenty-first with no trouble.

I had a marvelous time at the convention, exchanging comic patter with Randall Garrett and also with Robert Bloch (whom I now met for the first time and with whom I thereafter carried on a prolonged correspondence).

It would be impossible for me to explain the flavor of the long session a group of us had in some bar that first evening (with everyone but myself drinking steadily), but it seemed to us at the time that no group in the history of the world had ever been so consistently and devastatingly funny as we all were. We could hardly talk for laughing.

I can remember only one remark of that session. Someone mentioned that the duckbill platypus had a forked penis. I don't know whether this is true or not, but the statement was made. Whereupon I said, owlishly, "It is for that reason that a female platypus, on awaking in the morning with a male platypus in her bed, cries out, 'Good heavens, I've been forked/ "

It's no use telling me that this is not a very funny play on words, or even that you don't get it. That fact is that twenty-five people laughed for twenty-five solid minutes, and I don't care if most were drunk with alcohol and all were drunk on previous laughter, it was, as far as the effect went, one of the most successful witticisms I ever invented.